

colorlinks=true, linkcolor=black, citecolor=black,  
urlcolor=black, pdfborder=0 0 0

# Fate's Edge

## Essential Starting Guide

### GM & Player Reference — One Region, One Road

*“The road remembers. Every broken wheel leaves a mark, every lit lamp bears witness. The only question is: what are you willing to owe?” — Dusana of the Raven Road*

**Welcome to Fate's Edge.** This guide contains everything you need to start playing—core rules, character creation, one region (Acasia), GM procedures, and a starter adventure hook. No other books required.

## 1 The Philosophy of Consequence

### 1.1 Narrative First

**Every roll tells a story.** In Fate's Edge, mechanics serve the story. When you roll dice, you are not asking “did I succeed?”—you are asking “what happens next?”

**The Golden Rule:** When in doubt, make the choice that serves the story. Set DV=3, Position=Controlled, and let the dice fall.

### 1.2 Safety at the Table

Fate's Edge explores mature themes. Use these tools to keep play safe:

- **X-Card:** Any player may say “X” to stop a scene. No questions asked.
- **Lines:** Content that will not appear (e.g., “no harm to children”).
- **Veils:** Content that fades to black (e.g., “romance is implied, not described”).

Establish these in Session Zero.

## 2 The Core Resolution

### 2.1 The 90-Second Loop

Every meaningful action follows this cycle:

1. **Declare** your intent and approach (Attribute + Skill).
2. **GM sets DV** (2–5+) and **Position** (Dominant/Controlled/Desperate).
3. **Roll** dice pool (Attribute + Skill d10s).
4. **Count successes** (6–10 = 1 success). ~~Each 1–5 success carries weight —~~ Every story carries weight — Beat (SB) for GM.

### 2.3 Position

Position tells you how risky the action is and changes how dice behave:

| Position Effects |                     |                     |
|------------------|---------------------|---------------------|
| Position         | Frame               | Mechanical Effect   |
| Dominant         | You press advantage | Re-roll one failure |
| Controlled       | Balanced norm       | No re-rolls         |
| Desperate        | Act under duress    | Re-roll one success |

**Pro tip:** Spend 1 Boon to improve Position by one step before rolling.

### 2.4 The Outcome Matrix

| Outcome Matrix         |                                                   |
|------------------------|---------------------------------------------------|
| Roll Result            | What Happens                                      |
| Successes ≥ DV, SB = 0 | Clean Success – Intent achieved, no complication. |
| Successes ≥ DV, SB ≥ 0 | Success with SB – Intent achieved; GM spends SB.  |
| 0 < Successes < DV     | Partial – Progress; gain 1 Boon.                  |
| Successes = 0          | Miss – No progress; gain 2 Boons; GM spends SB.   |

**A Partial is not failure.** It moves the story forward: improve Position for next attempt, reduce DV, succeed at reduced scale, or reveal information.

**A Miss is never “nothing happens.”** The GM must introduce a complication.

### 2.5 Critical Success (10s)

A roll of 10 counts as **two successes**. If the overall roll succeeds:

- **1 ten:** Strong success—improve Position or gain minor advantage.
- **2 tens:** Exceptional—choose two benefits.
- **3+ tens:** Legendary—decisive victory; clear 1 segment from a relevant timer.

## 3 Resources: Boons & Story Beats

### 3.1 Boons—Player Currency

Boons represent luck, momentum, and narrative leverage. **Spend them freely.**

| Boons at a Glance  |                            |                                 |
|--------------------|----------------------------|---------------------------------|
| Earning Boons      | Gain                       | Spending Boons                  |
| Partial success    | Gain 1                     | Re-roll a die (1 Boon)          |
| Miss               | Gain 2                     | Improve Position (1 Boon)       |
| Bond-driven action | Gain 1 (once/bond/session) | Activate Asset (1 Boon)         |
| GM award           | +1 (rare)                  | Convert 2 → 1 XP (once/session) |

**Holding cap:** 5 Boons. At end of scene, reduce to 2 (excess lost).

**The Math of Fun:** Hoarding Boons for XP conversion starves the table of drama. A re-rolled failure or an improved Position creates a memorable moment. Spend Boons!

3.2 Story Beats (SB)—GM Currency

Every time a player rolls a 1, the GM gains Story Beats. Spend SB to introduce complications:

| SB Spend Menu |                                                          |
|---------------|----------------------------------------------------------|
| Cost          | Complication                                             |
| 1 SB          | Minor – noise, distraction, tick a timer +1              |
| 2 SB          | Moderate – alarm raised, lose advantage, worsen Position |
| 3+ SB         | Major – reinforcements, scene shifts, break an asset     |

**Be aggressive with SB.** Unused pressure is wasted momentum.

4 Injury & Exhaustion

4.1 Fatigue—The Weight of the World

Each point of Fatigue worsens your Position. If already Desperate, each Fatigue imposes –1 die instead.

| Fatigue Progression |                                                          |
|---------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|
| Fatigue Level       | Effect                                                   |
| 1                   | Position worsens one step                                |
| 2                   | If already Desperate, –1 die; otherwise Position worsens |
| 3                   | –2 dice (if already Desperate from Fatigue)              |
| 4+                  | Collapse, KO, incapacitated                              |

**Recovery:** Short rest removes 2 Fatigue; full night’s rest removes all.

4.2 Harm—Serious Injury

| Harm Levels |                           |
|-------------|---------------------------|
| Harm Level  | Effect                    |
| Harm 1      | –1 die on related actions |
| Harm 2      | –1 dice on most actions   |
| Harm 3      | Incapacitated or dying    |

4.3 The Roller-Coaster Effect

**Taking Harm clears Fatigue.** The shock of a wound resets your exhaustion. This creates dramatic swings—a character near collapse who takes a wound and finds a second wind.

4.4 Armor Conversion

When you take Harm, armor converts some to Fatigue:

| Armor Conversion |           |                    |                    |
|------------------|-----------|--------------------|--------------------|
| Armor            | Harm 1    | Harm 2             | Harm 3             |
| Light            | Fatigue 1 | Harm 1 + Fatigue 1 | Harm 2 + Fatigue 1 |
| Medium           | Fatigue 1 | Fatigue 1          | Harm 2 + Fatigue 1 |
| Heavy            | Fatigue 1 | Fatigue 1          | Fatigue 2          |

5 Building Your Character

5.1 10-Minute Checklist

- Start with **32 XP** (max 36 with Bonds/Complications).
- Concept:** One sentence (origin, profession, defining trait).
  - Attributes (1–5):** Spend XP—primary to 3 (9 XP), secondaries to 2 (6 XP each).
  - Skills (0–5):** Spend 8–12 XP on key skills.
  - Talents:** 1–3 talents (2–6 XP each).
  - Patron (optional):** Choose a Patron for magic.
  - Assets/Followers (optional):** Minor Asset (4 XP) or follower (Cap<sup>2</sup> XP).
  - Bonds & Complications:** Up to +4 XP total.

5.2 Attributes

| Attributes |                              |                              |
|------------|------------------------------|------------------------------|
| Attribute  | What It Does                 | Example Skills               |
| Body       | Strength, agility, endurance | Melee, Athletics, Stealth    |
| Wits       | Perception, quick thinking   | Insight, Lore, Investigation |
| Spirit     | Willpower, intuition         | Arcana, Resolve, Survival    |
| Presence   | Charisma, leadership         | Sway, Command, Deception     |

**Cost to raise:** New rating  $\times$  3 XP. Downtime = new rating in days.

### 5.3 Skills

**Cost to raise:** New level  $\times$  2 XP. Downtime = new level in days.

| Core Skills   |           |             |
|---------------|-----------|-------------|
| Combat        | Physical  | Social      |
| Melee         | Athletics | Sway        |
| Ranged        | Stealth   | Command     |
| Brawl         | Endurance | Deception   |
| Tactics       | Craft     | Performance |
|               | Survival  | Insight     |
| Knowledge     | Magic     |             |
| Lore          | Arcana    |             |
| Investigation | Ritual    |             |
| Medicine      |           |             |

### 5.4 Sample Starting Build—The Duelist (32 XP)

- **Attributes:** Body 3 (15 XP), Wits 2 (6 XP)
- **Skills:** Melee 2 (6 XP), Athletics 1 (2 XP)
- **Talent:** Keen Senses (2 XP)
- **Total:** 31 XP (bank 1)

## 6 The Known World: Acasia

*“The Broken Province”*

### 6.1 Genre & Mood

Low fantasy / mercenary realism / border feud. Acasia festers between the fallen Uтарan Empire and the ambitions of petty kings. Every bridge demands a price, and every road curves back to the same cursed crossroads.

### 6.2 What You Notice First

The smell of mildew on old parchment and wet ash. The way every milestone has been re-carved. The silence of a village that heard you coming and chose not to open its gates.

### 6.3 The One Rule That Kills Newcomers

Never sign a contract on a bridge. The river is a witness, and it never forgets a signature.

### 6.4 Key Factions

| Acasia Factions       |                  |                                   |
|-----------------------|------------------|-----------------------------------|
| Faction               | Leader           | Goal                              |
| Broken March          | Margravine Mira  | Keep the province from fracturing |
| Lame King's Claimants | Oren “Tin Crown” | Be recognized as true sovereign   |
| Free Companies        | Various captains | Find permanent contracts          |
| Blackwood Matriarchs  | Hedge-witches    | Survive the Curse                 |

### 6.5 The Curse of Acasia

The land remembers what we did—and what we failed to do. Every broken milestone is a forgotten promise. **Mechanical effect:** When you cross a bridge or crossroads, roll Spirit + Resolve (DV 3). On a failure, the Curse stirs—gain 1 Fatigue or a minor complication (GM's choice).

### 6.6 Acasia Mini-Generator (d6)

1. A bridge toll has tripled overnight; the toll-keeper is a deserter from your old company.
2. A hedge-witch offers to break your blood-debt—for the memory of your first kill.
3. The Lame King travels with a mute jester who writes prophecies on fallen leaves.
4. Bandits stole a Blackwood Matriarch's curse-box. Recover it before it opens.
5. A free company captain wants to hire you—but their last three hires died of “accidents.”

6. The Margravine's seal is missing. Whoever finds it can rewrite border law.

## 7 Running Fate's Edge

### 7.1 The GM Mindset

You are not a referee. You are a **co-creator of drama**. Your tools (SB, timers) are how you play the game.

### 7.2 Your Defaults

When in doubt:

- **DV: 3**
- **Position: Controlled**
- **Consequence:** Fatigue, time pressure, or exposure
- **Timers:** One short timer tied to the scene

### 7.3 The Three-Timer Guideline

Keep 1–3 active timers per scene:

| Timer Sizes |                                  |
|-------------|----------------------------------|
| Segments    | When to Use                      |
| 4           | Short, straightforward challenge |
| 6           | Standard scene or tension        |
| 8           | Extended or complex problem      |
| 10          | Epic or campaign-long pressure   |

### 7.4 GM Survival Tips

#### 7.4.1 When Players Go Off the Rails

Do not panic. Ask: *“What is your goal?”* Name the simplest obstacle—then set Position and DV.

#### 7.4.2 When Players Hoard Boons

Remind them: *“Boons are not XP tokens—they are dramatic fuel.”* Introduce time pressure.

#### 7.4.3 When a Scene Stalls

Ask a leading question, tick a timer, or cut to another player.

#### 7.4.4 When You Don't Know a Rule

Make a ruling that keeps the story moving. Default to DV 3, Controlled Position. Look it up later.

## 8 The Lantern at Dusk

*A Starter Adventure in Acasia*

### 8.1 Setup

The party is hired by **Elder Sarai** of Duskwood. A blight is spreading from the old barrow, where a cursed lantern was buried. The lantern must be brought to a stone circle to break the curse.

### 8.2 What the Party Knows

- The lantern is in the central chamber of the barrow.
- The barrow is guarded by restless spirits (the Duskwights).
- A rival treasure hunter, **Quick Lena**, has also entered the barrow.
- The curse will kill the village's crops in three days.

### 8.3 Timers

| Adventure Timers     |             |                                                              |
|----------------------|-------------|--------------------------------------------------------------|
| Clock                |             | Effect                                                       |
| <b>Barrow</b>        | <b>Col-</b> | Ticks on failure inside. At 6, entrance seals.               |
| <b>lapse [6]</b>     |             |                                                              |
| <b>Lena's Agenda</b> |             | Ticks each scene inside. At 4, Lena takes the lantern first. |
| <b>[4]</b>           |             |                                                              |

### 8.4 Scenes

#### 8.4.1 Scene 1—The Entry (DV 3, Controlled)

Obstacle: Cave-in blocks the way (Body + Athletics). **Partial:** Tick Barrow Collapse +1. **Miss:** Mark Harm 1, tick Collapse +1.

#### 8.4.2 Scene 2—The Spirit Corridor (DV 3, Controlled)

Three Duskwights demand an offering (a memory or a secret). Roll Presence + Sway. **Partial:** They also steal random equipment. **Miss:** They attack (Cap 2, Harm 1 each).

#### 8.4.3 Scene 3—The Lantern Chamber

Quick Lena tries to pry the lantern loose. Confront her: Presence + Sway (DV 3). **Partial:** She agrees to split the reward but demands a later favor (start Debt Timer [4]).

8.4.4 Scene 4—Escape (Skill Challenge)

The party needs **3 successes before 2 failures** to escape. DV 3, Position Desperate. Each failure ticks Barrow Collapse +1.

8.5 Resolution

Return the lantern to the stone circle. Break the curse with Spirit + Lore (DV 2). **Partial:** Curse lifts, but the lantern attracts another danger soon.

8.6 Advancement

Each PC earns **6–10 XP** at the end.

9 Basic Magic

9.1 The Five Paths (Quick Reference)

| Magic Paths |            |                   |      |                                |
|-------------|------------|-------------------|------|--------------------------------|
| Path        | Complexity | Cost              | Type | Best For                       |
| Runkeeper   | Low        | Obligation        |      | First-timers, reliable casters |
| Cantor      | Medium     | Corruption        |      | Bards, risk-takers             |
| Invoker     | Medium     | Obligation + time |      | Ritual specialists             |
| Summoner    | High       | Leash Boons       | +    | Pet-class fans                 |
| Free Caster | High       | Backlash          |      | Improvised players             |

For first magical characters, play a Runkeeper.

9.2 Runkeeper—The Reliable Path

**Requirements:** Familiar (Thiasos, 2 XP) + Codex (4 XP) + Patron.

**Invoking a Rite:** 1 action. Mark +1 Obligation. Effect works as written.

**Push It:** Once per scene, mark +1 Obligation to amplify (+1 die or +1 Effect).

**Obligation Capacity:** Spirit + Presence. Exceeding capacity = 1 Fatigue per segment.

9.3 Sample—The Traveler’s Runkeeper

**Kestra, Traveler’s Runkeeper** (36XP)

- Spirit 3 (9 XP), Wits 2 (6 XP)
- Lore 2 (6 XP), Insight 1 (2 XP), Sway 1 (2 XP)
- Talents: Familiar (2 XP), Codex (4 XP)
- Rites: Road-Sense (4 XP), Traveler’s Boon (5 XP)
- Obligation Capacity: 4 (Spirit 3 + Presence 1)

9.4 Free Casting—The TAGS System

For improvisational magic, construct spells using TAGS:

DV = 1 + number of TAGS

Dangerous TAGS (Leap, Fold, Gate, Transform, Dominate) add +2 DV.

9.4.1 Example Spells

- **Light** [Illuminate] – DV 2. Create small, sustained light.
- **HEAL** [HEAL] – DV 2. Remove 1 Fatigue from self or touched ally.
- **Shield of Air** [WARD] [DEFEND] – DV 3. Gain Position +1 on next defense.
- **Flame Cloak** [BURNING] [AREA] – DV 3. Enemies suffer –1 die to approach.
- **Backlash:** On a Miss or when GM spends SB, magic backfires—Fatigue 1, Harm 1, or a thematic complication.

10 Advancement & XP

10.1 Earning XP (Per Session)

| XP Breakdown     |      |
|------------------|------|
| Achievement      | XP   |
| Attendance       | +2   |
| Major objectives | +2–4 |
| Discoveries      | +1–2 |
| Hard choices     | +1–2 |
| Story engagement | +1–3 |
| Personal goals   | +1–2 |

**Game pace options:** Gritty (4–6 XP/session), Standard (6–10), Epic (10–14).

## 10.2 Spending XP

| XP Costs           |                |                    |
|--------------------|----------------|--------------------|
| Improvement        | XP Cost        | Downtime           |
| Attribute increase | New rating × 3 | New rating in days |
| Skill increase     | New level × 2  | New level in days  |
| Minor Asset        | 4 XP           | 1 day              |
| Standard Asset     | 8 XP           | 1 week             |
| Major Asset        | 12 XP          | 1 month            |
| Minor Talent       | 2–4 XP         | 3–10 days          |
| Major Talent       | 5–8 XP         | 1–2 weeks          |

## 10.3 Tiers of Play

| Character Tiers |          |             |
|-----------------|----------|-------------|
| Tier            | XP Range | Reputation  |
| I: Novice       | 0–40     | Local       |
| II: Seasoned    | 41–90    | Regional    |
| III: Veteran    | 91–150   | National    |
| IV: Paragon     | 151–220  | Continental |
| V: Mythic       | 221+     | Legendary   |

# 11 Quick Reference Tables

## 11.1 Combat in Brief

- **Turn:** 1 Action + 1 Move
- **Move:** Shift one range band (Close ↔ Near ↔ Far)
- **Opportunity Attack:** Leaving Close range without Disengage provokes one free melee attack.
- **Sidestep Strike:** Move one band as part of melee attack; worsen Position by one step.

## 11.2 Weapon Modifiers

| Melee Weapons |       |      |  |
|---------------|-------|------|--|
| Weight        | Close | Near |  |
| Light         | +2d   | +1d  |  |
| Medium        | +1d   | +2d  |  |
| Heavy         | –1d   | +3d  |  |

  

| Ranged Weapons |            |      |     |
|----------------|------------|------|-----|
| Weight         | Close      | Near | Far |
| Light          | Controlled | +1d  | —   |
| Medium         | Desperate  | +2d  | +1d |
| Heavy          | Desperate  | +1d  | +3d |

## 11.3 Range Bands

- **Close:** Touching distance
- **Near:** Same room/area—a rush away
- **Far:** Same site but distant—requires route or time

## 11.4 Skill Synergies—Creative Pairs

| Alternative Skill Pairs |                      |                                         |
|-------------------------|----------------------|-----------------------------------------|
| Action                  | Standard Pair        | Alternative Pair                        |
| Climbing                | Body + Athletics     | Wits + Athletics (clever route)         |
| Persuading              | Presence + Sway      | Wits + Sway (logical argument)          |
| Investigating           | Wits + Investigation | Spirit + Investigation (intuitive leap) |
| Feinting                | Wits + Melee         | Presence + Melee (intimidation)         |

## 11.5 Final GM Mantra

Set the DV low. Make the world react honestly. Let the pressure do the work. And remember—you are playing the game too.

# 12 Session Zero Checklist

1. **Lines & Veils** – Off-limits or implied content?
2. **Tone** – Action, survival, intrigue, or horror?
3. **Campaign length** – One-shot, short arc, or long campaign?
4. **Character hooks** – Each player shares one goal and one fear.
5. **Patron interest** – Which Patrons are already watching?
6. **Starting situation** – Where does the story begin?
7. **House rules** – Any optional subsystems?
8. **Scheduling & attendance** – Logistics for your table.
9. **Player-GM contract** – “We are co-creators, not adversaries.”
10. **Resource mindset** – “Boons are not XP tokens. Spend them. Embrace failure.”

“Now close the book—or keep reading. The road is waiting.”

*“The coin that never spends is the one you don’t remember taking.”*

— Serafine of the Velvet Touch

---

Fate’s Edge Essential Guide — CC BY 4.0 — Nicholas A. Gasper

*Set down in Castra Ferrum, Year of the Iron Harvest*